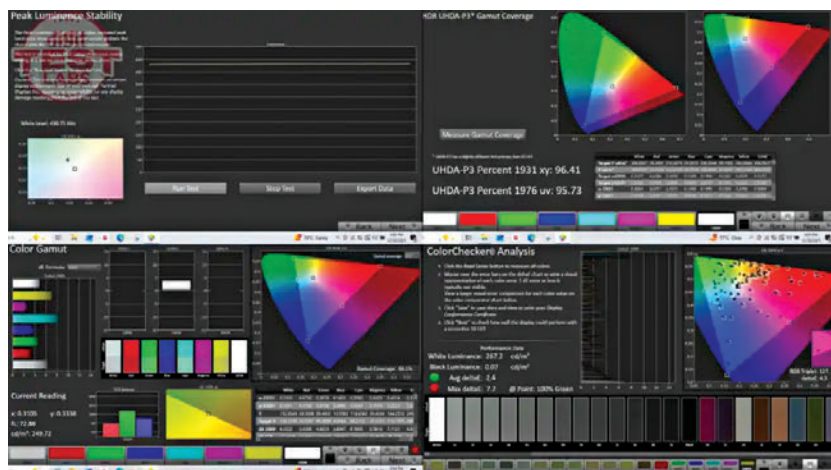




tures, like flicker and brightness control. HDR support is modest. The EW3290U monitor supports HDR10 and BenQ's HDRi processing. There are three HDR profiles for various scenarios, like Cinema, Game, and regular HDR. CinemaHDRi mode is similar to regular HDR and GameHDRi offers over-saturated colours. You can tweak the saturation, contrast etc in the settings, but since regular HDR looks the best out of the box, we stuck to it. In SDR content, if you select any of these HDR modes, the monitor offers an HDR simulated profile.

Nature colours and skin tones are passable, SDR content was pleasing, and casual creators will be happy. The claimed contrast ratio is 1000:1. HDR offers a decent amount of details in highlights and shadows, but with brightness in the DisplayHDR 400 class and no local dimming, it cannot deliver the dramatic contrast you see on a good TV. Even my MacBook Air offers sharper details, better clours, deeper contrast and blacks. While watching dark scenes in movies like Godzilla: Minus One, blacks lean towards dark grey.

In the Calman test, with the BenQ EW3290U monitor's regular HDR profile, the panel captured 98.1% gamut coverage in the BT 709 (SDR) profile and about 96% in the UHDA-P3 profile. The average deltaE was 2.4 in HDR. So, not for professionals or purists.

As for gaming, it is good for casual players. The monitor is locked to 60Hz, which is fine for story-driven titles. Visuals look sharp and vibrant, and the motion was smooth enough. BenQ has gaming modes and tweaks like AMA (Advanced Motion Acceleration) for smoother visuals, though I usually preferred sticking to the default settings.

AUDIO AND SOFTWARE

What adds to its entertainment value is the 2.1 speaker setup with a built-in woofer. It delivers a seemingly fuller sound with good bass. Dialogue sounds clear. I never looked for an external speaker, but I didn't always feel a need to find one either. For a small workspace, it feels like the right balance.

In terms of software, it doesn't have a built-in OS or app library like the Samsung Smart Monitor M7. Through the

remote or on-chassis buttons, you can tweak HDR profiles, usage scenarios, audio modes, and some system settings.

BenQ does give you a desktop tool called Display Pilot, though, which lets you switch modes from the desktop instead of searching menus. It may not feel essential, but it is good to have.

VERDICT

The 32-inch screen size and 4K resolution matter. Using the BenQ EW3290U as a second display helps me organise my work better. Email and notes live on my laptop. Anything related to reading, researching, editing tools like Canva and YouTube videos stays open on the bigger screen. There's less friction, less constant minimising, and fewer small annoyances throughout the day. Then, when the day ends, the same screen turns into a pretty decent entertainment setup. Respectable HDR, good colours, good sharpness, and sound that does not feel thin. Its connectivity options, a handy remote and ergonomic design make the switch between work and entertainment easy and comfortable.

You can get cheaper 4K screens in the market. But this offers a great balance of design, visuals, and features. It focuses on entertainment and everyday usability. So, the BenQ EW3290U makes a strong case if you want a screen that handles work through the day and movies at night without fuss.

—G. S. Vasan

SPECIFICATIONS

Display: 31.5-inch IPS VESA DisplayHDR 400 LED panel | Brightness: 430 nits (peak) | Refresh Rate: 60 Hz | Color Modes: Rec.709, sRGB, HDR, M-Book, Standard, User, Game, Cinema HDRi, Game HDRi | Aspect Ratio: 16:9 | PPI: 140 | Speaker: 2.1 Channel (2Wx2 + 5W woofer) | Ports: 3 HDMI, 1 USB C PowerDelivery, 1 USB C Downstream, 3 USB A Downstream

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